CHART YOUR COURSE

Could An ADU Work For Your Family?

Six ways families are using one property to solve two housing problems.

Close enough to be connected.
Separate enough to be independent.

Start at the kitchen table, not the drawing board.

DOWNSIZE BALTIMORE

MARY LYNCH | DOWNSIZE BALTIMORE

It’s Not Always a Cottage

Most people hear "ADU" and picture a small building out back. That picture stops a lot of good conversations before they start.

Families have lived this way for generations. Two households, one property, everybody with their own door. The permits are the new part.

An ADU is a second, smaller home on the same property as a single family house, with its own kitchen, bathroom, place to sleep, and way in and out. The word that matters is independent.

Here's what that can look like.
Three of these six use space you may already own.



Detached ADU



Attached ADU



Upper-Level ADU



Lower-Level ADU



Above-Garage ADU



Garage Conversion ADU

What an ADU is not. An extra bedroom. A basement with a mini fridge. A grown child in the guest room. A legal ADU meets the zoning, building, health, safety and permit requirements where you live.

Start with what you're trying to solve.
The floor plan comes a long way after that.

Six Ways Families Are Using Them

The reasons change from family to family. These are the ones I hear the most.

The situation	What an ADU can solve	A good first step
An adult child who isn't in a position to buy yet.	A real front door and real independence, without a rent payment that makes saving impossible.	Talk about how long, and what changes when it ends.
A parent close by, but not in the guest room.	Help that's easy to reach, and two households that keep their own routines.	Ask both households what privacy actually means to them.
Someone who helps.	A caregiver or family member close enough to be there, without sharing every meal.	Write down what help actually means before anyone moves in.
Rental income, where local rules allow it.	Some of the cost of the property carried by the property.	Confirm the rules first. This one is not permitted everywhere.
A house you're buying now.	Room for more than one household from day one, instead of a renovation later.	Bring this up before you start looking. It changes which houses work.
Space for the what ifs.	Room you don't need yet, ready for the year you do.	Build it no step and full bath, even if nobody needs that today.

If more than one row sounds like you, that's normal.
Circle the one you'd solve first if you could only solve one.

Before the Floor Plan

A good family idea still has to work on a real piece of land, under real rules, with real utilities.

Your county decides. Whether an ADU is allowed on your property, and what it takes to get approval, is a local question. Two families twenty minutes apart can get two different answers.

The land and the utilities. Lot shape, setbacks, parking, a safe path between the two doors, and whether you're on public water and sewer or a well and septic. If you're on septic, find out early what your system can support.

The house you already own. An apartment inside the house or an addition attached to it is often more practical than building new. Often, not always. It takes a look at the code and the layout to know.

The whole cost, not the construction estimate. Design, engineering, survey, permits and fees come before the first nail. Then property taxes, insurance, maintenance, and what a monthly payment does to the rest of your budget.

Build it to outlast the reason you built it. No step entry, a full bathroom on the living level, good lighting, wider doorways, real storage. The family member it's for today may not be the one using it in ten years.

Who ends up on your team. No one professional can answer all of this. Depending on the property, you may need your local planning and permitting office, an architect or designer, a contractor who has actually built one of these, a lender, an insurance advisor, and an attorney and tax professional for the ownership and estate questions.

You don't need every answer. You need to know which question belongs to which person.

Your First Small Plan

Four lines. That's the whole assignment.

The row on page three that sounds most like us:

The problem we're actually trying to solve:

One thing we'd have to find out before we could decide anything:

One person we should talk to about this, and when:

This is a family conversation, not a family announcement. The arrangements that work were talked about early, by everyone in them.

Need Help With the Bigger Picture?

Sometimes the hardest part isn't the building. It's figuring out what your options actually are, what the property will allow, what a change would cost, and what should happen first.

An ADU is one option on a longer list, and it isn't the right one for every family. Looking at it honestly, next to the alternatives, costs you nothing.

Whether it turns out to be an ADU or something else entirely, the question underneath is usually the same one. How do you stay close to the people you love without living on top of each other.

You don't have to be ready to build anything to have that conversation.

No pressure to build. No giant to-do list.
Just help figuring out the next right step.

Mary Lynch, a Certified Senior Advisor® with nearly 30 years in Baltimore real estate | Downsize Baltimore

(410) 375-1400
mary@downsizebaltimore.com | DownsizeBaltimore.com

Cummings & Co. Realtors
108 W. Timonium Road, Timonium, MD 21093 | Office (410) 823-0033